

neurodivers³

Sensory Audit Workbook

A guided audit of the sensory drains you have stopped noticing.

Print it, type into it, or do one room at a time.

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How this workbook works

Start anywhere. One page is enough.

What you need

- A pen, or a PDF reader with form filling.
- Time: 20–60 minutes.
- One room, screen, or routine to start with.
- Permission to stop after one page.

What this is / isn't

- This workbook is not asking you to fix your whole environment. It is asking you to notice where your body is already spending energy.
- The point is to notice the light you keep squinting through, the hum you have tuned out until someone switches it off, the chair you only realise hurts after you stand up.
- Work through one room, one domain, or one page at a time. Stop if it starts making you feel worse. The win is not a perfect environment; it is one less thing your nervous system has to fight.

How to work

- Notice first.
- Score the drain.
- Pick the smallest useful fix.
- Park anything too big for later.

Worth remembering:

If your first honest answer is "everything", begin with the room you avoid most — that avoidance is usually the audit already pointing at the answer.

The seven domains

These are the seven places sensory load usually hides.

Light

Glare, flicker, brightness, contrast, shadows, bulbs, screens, sunlight bouncing off surfaces. (*overhead light, winter darkness, screen glare, bathroom mirror light*)

Sound

Appliances, traffic, voices, hums, buzzes, sudden noises, neighbour noise, extractor fans. (*fridge hum, road noise, notification sounds, kettle roar*)

Smell

Cleaning products, food smells, damp, perfume, bins, laundry, candles, body products. (*old sponge smell, scented detergent, lingering cooking smells*)

Temperature

Heat, cold, draughts, humidity, sudden changes, rooms that never feel right. (*cold bathroom floor, overheated bedroom, draughty desk*)

Clothing / touch

Seams, labels, waistbands, fabrics, pressure, textures, wet sleeves, hair touching skin. (*sock seams, scratchy jumper, tight waistband, damp cuffs*)

Posture / body load

Seating, desk height, standing position, carrying, leaning, pain points, muscle tension. (*chair too low, laptop angle, sofa slump, standing at the sink*)

Screen / visual load

Brightness, clutter, tabs, notifications, visual noise, motion, contrast, messy desktops. (*47 tabs, app badges, bright white pages, moving backgrounds*)

You are not looking for proof that you are "too sensitive". You are looking for inputs.

Score the drain, then triage the fix

Two quick scales make every later decision easier: how much a drain costs you, and how hard it is to fix.

Drain score

- 1** = I notice it, but it barely costs me.
- 2** = It irritates me sometimes.
- 3** = It costs energy most days.
- 4** = I avoid things because of it.
- 5** = It can derail the whole day.

Fix difficulty

Free = move, remove, turn down, swap, open, close, mute, rearrange.

Cheap = small purchase under £25, basic replacement, simple tool.

Bigger = landlord, partner, housemate, workplace, money, time, structural change.

The rule:

Start with high-drain, free or cheap fixes. Park the bigger fixes unless they are urgent or unsafe.

Tiny worksheet

The sensory drain I already know about:

My current drain score:

The smallest possible fix:

Is it Free, Cheap, or Bigger?

Light audit

For glare, flicker, brightness, contrast, shadows, bulbs, and screen light.

Where do I notice this most?

What have I normalised?

What does my body do when this is too much?

What could I remove, soften, or reduce?

Trigger table

Trigger	Where	Drain 1-5	Free/Cheap/Bigger	First tiny fix

Suggested tiny light fixes:

- turn off one overhead light
- change curtain timing
- move seat away from glare
- swap bulb warmth
- reduce screen brightness

Sound audit

For hums, buzzes, voices, traffic, appliances, notifications, and sudden noise.

Where do I notice this most?

What have I normalised?

What does my body do when this is too much?

What could I remove, soften, or reduce?

Trigger table

Trigger	Where	Drain 1-5	Free/Cheap/Bigger	First tiny fix

Suggested tiny sound fixes:

- mute one device
- headphones/earplugs
- add brown noise
- move appliance timing
- close a door

Smell audit

For cleaning products, food smells, damp, perfume, bins, laundry, and lingering smells.

Where do I notice this most?

What have I normalised?

What does my body do when this is too much?

What could I remove, soften, or reduce?

Trigger table

Trigger	Where	Drain 1-5	Free/Cheap/Bigger	First tiny fix

Suggested tiny smell fixes:

- change detergent
- open window after cooking
- clean one hidden source
- move bin
- remove scented product

Temperature audit

For heat, cold, draughts, humidity, and rooms that never feel right.

Where do I notice this most?

What have I normalised?

What does my body do when this is too much?

What could I remove, soften, or reduce?

Trigger table

Trigger	Where	Drain 1-5	Free/Cheap/Bigger	First tiny fix

Suggested tiny temperature fixes:

- add socks/slippers near cold area
- change blanket access
- use fan/dehumidifier if already available
- move seat away from draught
- adjust heating timer

Clothing / touch audit

For seams, labels, fabrics, pressure, textures, wet sleeves, and body contact irritation.

Where do I notice this most?

What have I normalised?

What does my body do when this is too much?

What could I remove, soften, or reduce?

Trigger table

Trigger	Where	Drain 1-5	Free/Cheap/Bigger	First tiny fix

Suggested tiny clothing / touch fixes:

- remove labels
- change socks
- put sensory-safe layer nearby
- create safe-clothes basket
- loosen waistband

Posture / body load audit

For seating, desk height, standing positions, carrying, leaning, and avoidable body strain.

Where do I notice this most?

What have I normalised?

What does my body do when this is too much?

What could I remove, soften, or reduce?

Trigger table

Trigger	Where	Drain 1-5	Free/Cheap/Bigger	First tiny fix

Suggested tiny posture / body load fixes:

- raise laptop
- move heavy item lower
- change foot position
- add cushion
- sit for one task usually done standing

Screen / visual load audit

For brightness, clutter, tabs, notifications, motion, contrast, and visual noise.

Where do I notice this most?

What have I normalised?

What does my body do when this is too much?

What could I remove, soften, or reduce?

Trigger table

Trigger	Where	Drain 1-5	Free/Cheap/Bigger	First tiny fix

Suggested tiny screen / visual load fixes:

- hide app badges
- use reader mode
- create one calm working screen
- close visual clutter
- reduce motion

Kitchen walkthrough

Kitchens are noisy, bright, smelly, textured, and full of transitions. No wonder they can become avoidance rooms.

QUICK SENSORY SCAN*What feels loudest here?*

Light

Sound

Smell

Temp

Touch

Body

Visual

What do I notice?

What do I brace against?

What do I avoid here?

What feels loudest?

What could change?

FREE FIX**CHEAP FIX****BIGGER FIX**

FIRST CHANGE: WHAT IS THE FIRST CHANGE I AM ACTUALLY MAKING?

Worth remembering:

If cooking feels like too many transitions, change one input (mute the extractor fan or sit down to prep) rather than trying to tidy the whole space first.

Bedroom walkthrough

A bedroom can look "fine" and still be quietly hostile to rest.

QUICK SENSORY SCAN

What feels loudest here?

Light

Sound

Smell

Temp

Touch

Body

Visual

What do I notice?

What do I brace against?

What do I avoid here?

What feels loudest?

What could change?

FREE FIX**CHEAP FIX****BIGGER FIX**

FIRST CHANGE: WHAT IS THE FIRST CHANGE I AM ACTUALLY MAKING?

Worth remembering:

A bedroom is for recovery. If you cannot sleep, don't try to solve your life in the dark — change one light or blanket and notice if your body softens.

Living room walkthrough

Shared spaces often carry hidden sensory compromises.

QUICK SENSORY SCAN

What feels loudest here?

Light

Sound

Smell

Temp

Touch

Body

Visual

What do I notice?

What do I brace against?

What do I avoid here?

What feels loudest?

What could change?

FREE FIX**CHEAP FIX****BIGGER FIX**

FIRST CHANGE: WHAT IS THE FIRST CHANGE I AM ACTUALLY MAKING?

Worth remembering:

In shared spaces, you do not need permission to protect your own energy. A pair of headphones or a screen angle is a boundary, not a rejection.

Bathroom walkthrough

Bathrooms are full of cold floors, echo, bright mirrors, smells, damp, and abrupt transitions.

QUICK SENSORY SCAN*What feels loudest here?*

Light

Sound

Smell

Temp

Touch

Body

Visual

What do I notice?

What do I brace against?

What do I avoid here?

What feels loudest?

What could change?

FREE FIX**CHEAP FIX****BIGGER FIX**

FIRST CHANGE: WHAT IS THE FIRST CHANGE I AM ACTUALLY MAKING?

Worth remembering:

Bathrooms are highly transient. Changing one tactile transition (a softer towel or a warm floor mat) can completely change how starting the day costs you.

Workspace / desk walkthrough

The place where you try to function can also be the place draining the function out of you.

QUICK SENSORY SCAN*What feels loudest here?*

Light

Sound

Smell

Temp

Touch

Body

Visual

What do I notice?

What do I brace against?

What do I avoid here?

What feels loudest?

What could change?**FREE FIX****CHEAP FIX****BIGGER FIX****FIRST CHANGE: WHAT IS THE FIRST CHANGE I AM ACTUALLY MAKING?****Worth remembering:**

Your workspace is not a test of endurance. If you are masking just to sit at your desk, the setup is draining the function out of you.

Hallways, entrances, transitions walkthrough

Transition spaces matter because they decide how hard it is to start, leave, arrive, and recover.

QUICK SENSORY SCAN*What feels loudest here?*

Light

Sound

Smell

Temp

Touch

Body

Visual

What do I notice?

What do I brace against?

What do I avoid here?

What feels loudest?

What could change?

FREE FIX**CHEAP FIX****BIGGER FIX**

FIRST CHANGE: WHAT IS THE FIRST CHANGE I AM ACTUALLY MAKING?

Worth remembering:

Transition zones dictate how you arrive and leave. Keep them clear of visual clutter so your nervous system doesn't have to navigate a maze before you even start.

Outside the home walkthrough

You may not control the supermarket, commute, workplace, car, or street — but you can still identify what costs the most.

QUICK SENSORY SCAN*What feels loudest here?*

Light

Sound

Smell

Temp

Touch

Body

Visual

What do I notice?

What do I brace against?

What do I avoid here?

What feels loudest?

What could change?**FREE FIX****CHEAP FIX****BIGGER FIX****FIRST CHANGE: WHAT IS THE FIRST CHANGE I AM ACTUALLY MAKING?****Worth remembering:**

You cannot control the supermarket or street, but you can always carry a sensory tool or choose when to leave. Avoidance is sometimes a smart boundary.

Master findings

Part 1 of 2

Put everything in one place before deciding what to change.

Where	Domain	What is draining me	Drain 1-5	Free/Cheap/Bigger	First fix	Done?

Capture rule:

Write the drain down even if you do not know the fix yet.

Master findings (continued)

Part 2 of 2

Put everything in one place before deciding what to change.

[illegible]

PATTERN SPOTTER: WHAT KEEPS SHOWING UP?

Most repeated space

Most repeated domain

Fix I keep circling back to

The first change I am actually making

One change counts. You are not renovating your entire nervous system this week.

The one change I am trying first is

I chose this because

It is Free / Cheap / Bigger

I will do it by

I will know it helped if

I will check again on

If this works, you can do another one later. If it does not, it was data.

Free fixes this week

Free fixes do not need to become a whole life reset. One per day is enough.

Day	Fix	Where	Done?
Monday			
Tuesday			
Wednesday			
Thursday			
Friday			
Saturday			
Sunday			

KEEP IT FREE

This box gives the page context and prevents "free fix" from turning into a bigger project:

- No shopping
- No full-room resets
- No "while I'm here I might as well..."
- Stop before the fix becomes a new drain

Cheap fixes this month

Cheap does not mean trivial. Sometimes a £6 bulb or a £12 pair of earplugs changes how a whole room feels.

My budget for this month:

[illegible]

Running total:

Bigger fixes parking lot

These are not failures. They are fixes that need money, permission, time, another person, a landlord, or a workplace process.

[illegible]

Last reviewed date:

Parking something is not ignoring it. It is refusing to carry it in your head every day.

A message you can adapt

Use this for landlords, housemates, partners, family, or work. Delete anything that does not fit.

MESSAGE

Hi _____,

I want to ask about _____, because it is affecting
_____.

The main problem is _____. I have noticed that it is costing me energy
because _____.

Would it be possible to _____ by _____?

I am not asking for everything to be perfect. I am trying to reduce one thing that is making the space
harder to use.

Thanks,

Write your own message

NOTES & SCHEDULER:

What I need to change before sending

Who this is going to

When I will send it

30-day re-audit

Sensory needs move with seasons, stress, hormones, workload, illness, grief, sleep, and life. Re-auditing is not starting again. It is maintenance.

What changed?

What did not matter as much as expected?

What helped more than expected?

What sensory drain came back?

What do I want to keep?

What is the next smallest change?

Next scheduled re-audit date:

Before you go

Where this fits

Free Sensory Audit lab

The quick browser version, for a faster pass with nothing to print.

neurodivers3.co.uk/labs

The essay

The story behind why sensory load goes invisible until it hurts.

neurodivers3.co.uk/blog

Burnout Recovery Roadmap

For when the environment is part of a bigger burnout pattern.

neurodivers3.co.uk/store

Newsletter

One honest email when there's something worth saying.

neurodivers3.co.uk/newsletter

About neurodivers³

neurodivers³ is a home for honest stories, practical tools, and ideas for making everyday life work better with a neurodivergent brain. I make resources for late-diagnosed and self-identified neurodivergent adults who are tired of being told to try harder at systems that were never built for them. This workbook is not a clinical tool. It is a practical one. Use what helps; leave what does not.

— Ollie

Feedback invitation:

If this helped, or if something didn't fit, I would genuinely like to know. Reply any time at hello@neurodivers3.co.uk. It quietly shapes what I make next.

Refundable for 14 days, no questions. Email hello@neurodivers3.co.uk within 14 days of purchase.